The Zimmermann Telegram

German Foreign Sec. Arthur Zimmermann to German Minister in Mexico · January 16, 1917

Source: Zimmermann Telegram (Jan. 1917), decoded English text via the U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents. Public domain.

British intelligence intercepted and decoded this telegram in January 1917 and shared it with the U.S. on February 24. In it, the German Foreign Office proposed that if the U.S. entered World War I, Mexico should ally with Germany in exchange for the recovery of Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona. President Wilson made the text public on March 1. Combined with Germany's resumption of unrestricted submarine warfare, the telegram pushed Congress to declare war on April 6, 1917.

Connect: Wilson entered WWI to 'make the world safe for democracy.' Compare his framing to McKinley's justification for the Spanish-American War (Class 33). What's the same tactic?

Key Passages

The submarine gamble

We intend to begin on the first of February unrestricted submarine warfare. We shall endeavor in spite of this to keep the United States of America neutral.

The offer to Mexico

In the event of this not succeeding, we make Mexico a proposal of alliance on the following basis: make war together, make peace together, generous financial support and an understanding on our part that Mexico is to reconquer the lost territory in Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona.

Japan and the endgame

You will inform the President of the above most secretly as soon as the outbreak of war with the United States of America is certain and add the suggestion that he should, on his own initiative, invite Japan to immediate adherence and at the same time mediate between Japan and ourselves. Please call the President's attention to the fact that the ruthless employment of our submarines now offers the prospect of compelling England in a few months to make peace.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	World War I: the U.S. was still neutral, Germany was resuming unrestricted submarine warfare, and U.S.-Mexico tensions followed Pershing's expedition against Villa.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The German minister in Mexico, to pass the proposal to the Mexican government; after interception, the American public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Arthur Zimmermann and German leaders, who hoped a Mexican alliance would keep the U.S. busy at home; it was never meant for American eyes.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Place the Zimmermann Telegram in the broader context of U.S. neutrality, 1914–1917.
2. Why did Mexico — under Carranza — decline the offer?
3. Identify TWO other reasons besides the telegram that pushed the U.S. into WWI.

The Zimmermann Telegram

Arthur Zimmermann, conveyed by Ambassador Walter Page · February 24, 1917

Source: Zimmermann Telegram (Jan. 1917), decoded English text via the U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents. Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> Germany's secret proposal that Mexico join it in war against the United States — in return for Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona — was intercepted by Britain and helped push the U.S. into World War I.

The decoded telegram

"We intend to begin on the first of February unrestricted submarine warfare. We shall endeavor in spite of this to keep the United States of America neutral. In the event of this not succeeding, we make Mexico a proposal of alliance on the following basis: make war together, make peace together, generous financial support and an understanding on our part that Mexico is to reconquer the lost territory in Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona. The settlement in detail is left to you. You will inform the President of the above most secretly as soon as the outbreak of war with the United States of America is certain and add the suggestion that he should, on his own initiative, invite Japan to immediate adherence and at the same time mediate between Japan and ourselves. Please call the President's attention to the fact that the ruthless employment of our submarines now offers the prospect of compelling England in a few months to make peace." Signed, ZIMMERMANN.

Words to know

unrestricted submarine warfare — sinking any ship, including neutral and civilian vessels, without warning

neutral — not taking sides in the war

reconquer — take back by force

adherence — joining the alliance

mediate — act as a go-between to arrange peace